

PECAN+ Capture The Flag 2026

Impact Snapshot



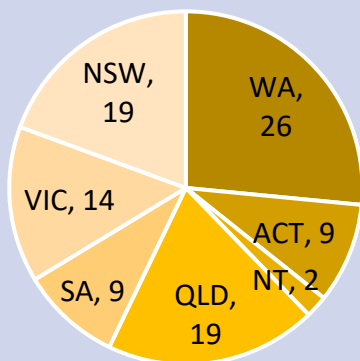
INTRODUCTION

PECAN+ Capture The Flag (CTF) is a free, national cyber security competition for beginner through to advanced high school-aged participants. PECAN+ CTF is a collaborative initiative, led by Edith Cowan University, which brings together Australian higher education and vocational institutions, cyber security industry, government, teachers and students around the aim of raising cyber security awareness, skills and aspirations.

The PECAN+ CTF 2026 Competition, held on August 23rd, 2026, was preceded by a range of national Training opportunities to upskill and prepare students to tackle cyber security and problem-solving challenges.

2026 ENGAGEMENT FIGURES

PECAN+ CTF 2026 saw participation by **98 Teams** of high-school aged competitors (years 9-12). Total, national registration numbers were 422 students.



13

All Female Teams
+ further female and non-binary competitors.

Divisions of Teams

Advanced (10)

Intermediate (29)

Beginner (59)

2026 NATIONAL HOSTS & LOCATIONS

PECAN+ CTF is led by Edith Cowan University (Western Australia) and invites collaborators around Australia to host PECAN+ CTF activations and create opportunity for students across all States and Territories to participate. In 2026, PECAN+ CTF activations were located in:

- WA: Edith Cowan University, Joondalup Campus.
- NT: Charles Darwin Centre – led by NT Department of Corporate and Digital Development.
- SA: Adelaide University - led by Starknex.
- QLD: TAFE Queensland South Bank, Coomera, Sunshine Coast & Townsville Campuses – led by Cyber In Motion.
- ACT: University of Canberra – led by Canberra Cyber Hub.
- NSW: University of New South Wales (UNSW), Sydney Campus (inaugural year).
- NSW: University of Wollongong, Wollongong Campus.
- VIC: Box Hill Institute, Box Hill Campus.

11 national Training & Competition sites.



2026 SPONSORS AND SUPPORTERS

National Lead

- Edith Cowan University School of Science

2026 Platinum Sponsor

- Australian Signals Directorate

2026 Gold Sponsors

- Australian Information Security Association (AISA)
- Triskele Labs
- CyberWest Hub

2026 Silver Sponsors

- Western Australia Office of Digital Government
- LevelBlue

Platform Sponsor

- Kasm Workspaces

Technology Lead

- Tom Plant

+ local Sponsors and supporters.



Australian Government

Australian Signals Directorate



Department of the Premier and Cabinet
Office of Digital Government

LevelBlue

CYBER TRAINING ACTIVITIES

PECAN+ supports the development of cyber security skills in youth. To prepare participants, training activities were offered across the country in the lead up to PECAN+ CTF Competition Day. Training addresses topics ranging from: cyber tools; Linux skills; cryptography; steganography; digital forensics; OSINT; reverse engineering; web exploitation and more.

Under a whole-of-cyber-ecosystem model, PECAN+ training was delivered by TAFE and university students, Industry and Government representatives and cyber security academics. Embedded in Training Days were additional guest presentations and panel sessions from Government and Industry representatives.

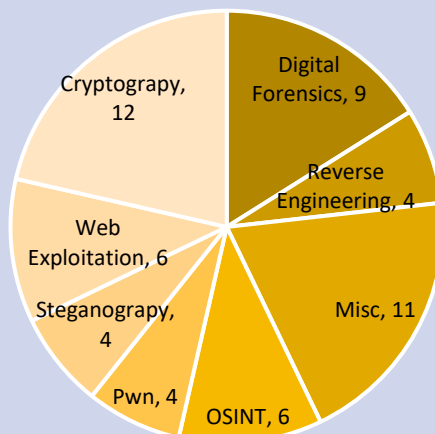


CHALLENGES

PECAN+ is a Capture The Flag (CTF) style of competition that sees students tackle challenges using cyber security and problem-solving skills. The goal of each challenge is to recover a novel string of text - letters, numbers and characters - called a "flag".

All PECAN+ CTF 2026 challenges were created and contributed by national TAFE and University students and members of the greater cyber security ecosystem.

Fifty-six (56) CTF challenges were presented during the 2026 competition, across a range of categories:



The most popular challenges, based on feedback on "favourite challenge" from 130 respondents, were found in the category themes of OSINT, Digital Forensics, Cryptography and Steganography.

STUDENT FEEDBACK

The response to PECAN+ CTF 2026 is overwhelmingly positive. Feedback from 130 respondents (i.e.; 2026 competitors) indicates:

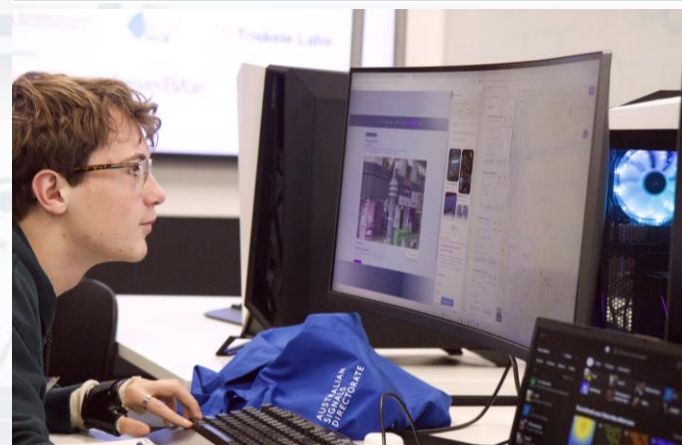
- A shift in experience and confidence in addressing cyber security challenges from 2.47 to **3.38** (out of 5), on av., following participation in PECAN+ CTF 2026.
- That participation in PECAN+ CTF 2026 increased interest in cyber security by a **3.82** av. rating (where 5 = exceptionally increased).
- An average **4.00** (out of 5) rating for the whole of PECAN+ CTF 2026 experience.
- That **85%** of respondents will compete in PECAN+ CTF again.

Positive themes in the feedback for PECAN+ CTF 2026 included strong use of the words: "**fun**", "**training**" and "**challenge**".

2026 PRIZE WINNERS

National prizes were awarded to a total of 11 Teams in WA (3), VIC (2), QLD (3), ACT (1), NSW (1) and SA (1). PECAN+ CTF focuses on inclusion of all skill levels and diversity of experience and background. Prizes were awarded across Beginner, Intermediate and Advanced divisions and to Top All Female (and non-binary) member Teams.

All Competitors were provided with Certificates of Participation and a token 2026 PECAN+ CTF competitor Challenge Coin, in recognition of their achievement.



"The program is good, it was run really well, and I especially enjoyed that we all could be a social."

"Yes, definitely do that again."

"Thanks for 3 years of CTF fun. Really enjoyed each year."

"Great event"

"It was a very fun event, huge thank you to all the helpers involved which helped make the event enjoyable. Would have definitely participated again if I [could]."

- Feedback from PECAN+ CTF 2026 competitors.